Workbook 4: The Product Dimension

Class2Career: Building What Matters
By Ignis Spindler

Introduction: Product Is a Verb

When you hear "product," you probably think of software, physical goods, or apps. But product is bigger than that.

Product is a mindset. It's the discipline of identifying what people need and delivering it in the simplest, most valuable way.

Your instructor calls this "the product lens" — a filter for understanding how someone else derives value from the thing you give them. Whether you're building software, writing a report, or designing a process, you're creating a product.

In this workbook, you'll learn: 1. **What product really means** — beyond the obvious 2. **How to think like a product manager** — even if you're not one 3. **The value proposition framework** — why people buy 4. **Agile methodology** — building iteratively

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Part 1: Understanding Product

It's Not Just Software

Your instructor: "Product is my favorite. It's very qualitative. You have to think about the word product like it's a verb."

Think about product in any business context:

- **A restaurant** — the menu, the food, the experience
- **A consulting service** — the expertise, the deliverables, the relationship
- **A report** — the insights, the formatting, the recommendations

Everything that gets delivered to someone else is a product.

The Product Mindset

Here's the core insight: **Product is about solving problems, not building features.**

Your instructor shares: "One of the worst problems I experience working with academics is when they can't give me constraints on what they need. They think they need everything. That means they don't know what they're looking for."

In business, scope matters. You need to narrow the problem space so others can collaborate with you efficiently. That's why industry is efficient — people care about getting work done iteratively, quickly, failing fast, moving forward.

The Product Cycle

1. **Identify a problem** — What pain point exists?
2. **Define the solution** — What minimum viable thing solves it?
3. **Build it** — Start small, iterate fast
4. **Launch** — Get feedback
5. **Iterate** — Improve based on real usage
6. **Scale** — Do more of what works

This cycle applies to everything from building software to writing a proposal.

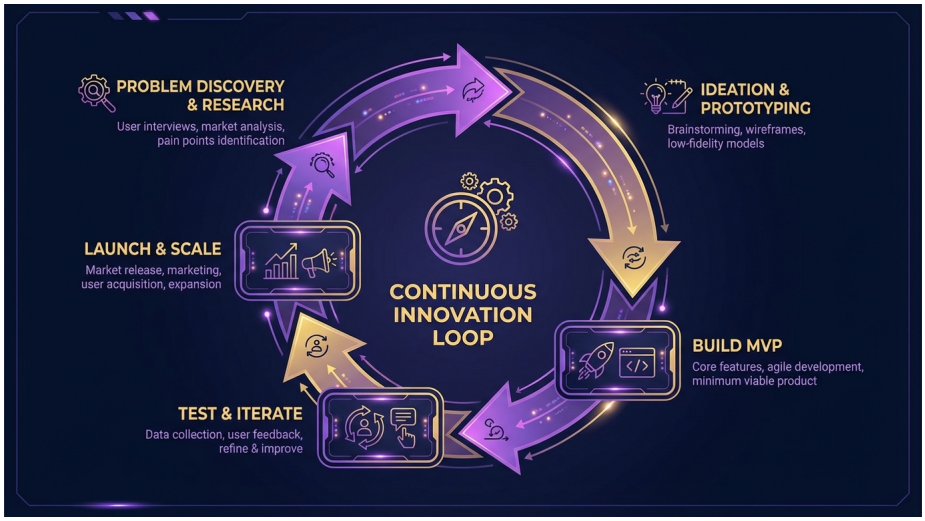

Figure 1: Product Development Workflow

Part 2: Value Proposition

What Is a Value Proposition?

A value proposition answers: **Why should someone choose you?**

Your instructor: "In product, you are looking for something to be the facilitator of value. You're looking for a convincing amount of utility."

Value proposition and market fit are closely linked:

- **Market fit** = demand exists for what you're selling
- **Value proposition** = why they should buy from you vs. someone else

How to Find Market Fit

Your instructor recommends *The Mom Test* by Rob Fitzpatrick:

> The book teaches you to ask the right questions. Talk to potential customers. Ask what they actually do, not what they say they'd want.

Bad question: "Would you buy a recipe app?" **Good question:** "What apps do you actually use? How often do you cook?"

The first question gets you a polite lie. The second gets you truth.

The Value Proposition Canvas

Answer these questions:

1. **Who is your customer?**
2. **What problem do they have?**
3. **What is their current solution?**
4. **What's the gap?** (Where does the current solution fail?)
5. **What's your solution?**
6. **Why is yours better?**

If you can't answer all six, you don't have a value proposition.

Competitive Advantage

Your instructor: "What sets us apart from our competition is a big question everyone in business should be asking."

You should know: - Who is your #1 competitor? - Why should customers choose you instead? - What makes your solution unique?

Part 3: The Product Lens at Work

Apply It to Your Job

You don't need a "product manager" title to think like one.

Your instructor: "I can adapt the mindset of what product taught me because it allows me to have more agency and control the shape of my deliverable."

Before you start any project, ask:

1. **What does the person actually want?** (Not what they asked for)
2. **What format do they need?** (Spreadsheet? Graph? Report?)
3. **What's the minimum valuable deliverable?**
4. **How will this be used?**

Your instructor: "If I don't know whether they want a graph or a spreadsheet, I won't start. I'll ask first. Because I'll do different things to get myself there efficiently."

The MVP Approach

MVP = Minimum Viable Product

The smallest thing you can build that still delivers value.

Your instructor: "In data science, I don't want to build a full model and realize three weeks later that I misunderstood the problem. I want to give them one number on Day 1. Then I can iterate."

Scope Control

In academia, you explore endlessly. In business, you narrow scope.

Your instructor: "You have to whittle down a problem space so other people can collaborate with you better. That's why industry is efficient."

Learn to say: "Here's what I can deliver in the first iteration. Then we can expand."

Part 4: Agile Methodology

What Is Agile?

Agile is a framework for managing projects by delivering value incrementally.

Your instructor: "Agile has become a language for task management. It's the most common system out there. Accept it for what it is — useful training wheels."

The Core Philosophy

Waterfall: Build everything → Launch everything → Get feedback **Agile:** Build piece → Get feedback → Adjust → Build next piece

Your instructor's analogy: Building a car

- **Waterfall:** Give them nothing for 3 months, then hand over a car
- **Agile:** Day 1 = skateboard (they can get to work faster). Week 4 = bike. Month 2 = chassis. Month 3 = working car.

The goal: Deliver value at every stage.

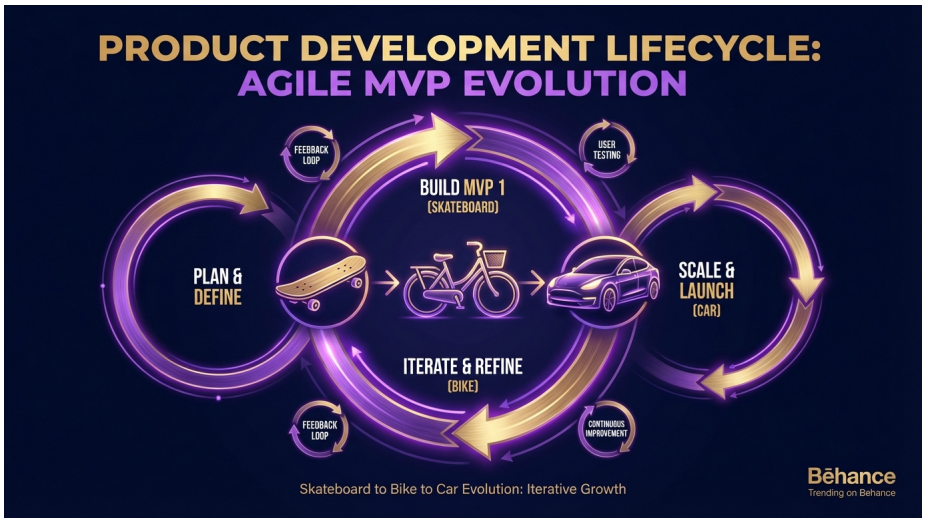

Figure 2: Product Development Cycle

Agile Terminology

- **Epic** — A large project broken into smaller pieces (e.g., "Build the car")
- **Story** — A small, deliverable piece of work (e.g., "Install wheels")
- **Spike** — Research to understand complexity (no deliverable, just learning)
- **Bug** — Something broken that needs fixing
- **Sprint** — A time-boxed period (usually 1-2 weeks) to complete stories
- **Backlog** — Prioritized list of work to be done

Why Agile Works

1. **Feedback early** — Catch problems before they've compound
2. **Adaptability** — Change direction based on reality
3. **Visibility** — Everyone sees progress
4. **Motivation** — Regular wins keep teams engaged

Your Role in Agile

Even if you're not on an Agile team, you can apply the principles:

1. **Chunk your work** — Break big projects into smaller deliverable pieces
2. **Deliver early** — Give something usable ASAP
3. **Get feedback** — Ask: "Is this what you need?"
4. **Iterate** — Improve based on input

Your instructor: "If you see something happening inefficiently, make it better. Make it work, then make it better, then make it fast."

Part 5: Building Your Product Skills

Think Like a Product Manager

1. **Start with the customer** — Who are you solving for?
2. **Define the problem** — What's the pain point?
3. **Find the simplest solution** — Don't over-engineer
4. **Test it** — Get real feedback, not hypotheticals
5. **Iterate** — Improve continuously

Ask Better Questions

Your instructor: "Asking the right questions is a skill. There's a whole industry built on it."

Before you build anything: - What does success look like? - What will they do with this? - What's the simplest version that still helps?

Document Your Work

In product, documentation is value.

Your instructor: "Documentation adds equity to a business. Without it, when the person who knew how to do the thing leaves, the knowledge leaves with them."

- Write down processes
- Create templates
- Share learnings

Part 6: Your Path — The Three Tracks

Track A: Undergraduate / Early Career

Your challenge: You haven't yet thought of yourself as a "product" creator.

Your focus: - Practice defining the "what" before the "how" - Learn to ask clarifying questions - Start small

Your assignment: 1. For one task this week, define the minimum deliverable before you start 2. Practice asking: "What will you do with this?" 3. Break one big project into 3 smaller pieces

Track B: Master's / Mid-Level Transition

Your challenge: You have expertise but haven't framed it as a product.

Your focus: - Apply the value proposition framework - Connect your work to customer outcomes - Learn Agile terminology

Your assignment: 1. Write a value proposition for your expertise 2. Identify your "customer" (who uses your work) 3. Practice: Deliver one small piece, get feedback, iterate

Track C: PhD / Senior Professional Pivot

Your challenge: Deep expertise. Risk of over-building.

Your focus: - Simplify your message - Lead with outcomes, not methods - Coach others on product thinking

Your assignment: 1. Explain your expertise as a product: "I solve [X] for [Y]" 2. Identify the MVP version of your next project 3. Teach someone else the product mindset

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Part 7: Public Sector Transition

Coming from government or non-profit? Here's how product translates:

Public Sector	Private Sector
Compliance-driven	Outcome-driven
Process-first	Customer-first
Stability	Iteration
Budget allocation	Market validation

What Transfers

- Problem identification
- Needs assessment
- Stakeholder communication
- Documentation

What You Need to Learn

- Speed and iteration
- Market validation
- MVP thinking
- Competitive analysis

Workbook Exercises

Exercise 1: The Value Proposition

For a product or service you're interested in: - Who is the customer? - What problem do they have? - What's the solution? - Why is it better than alternatives?

Exercise 2: The MVP

Choose a project you're working on: - What's the minimum valuable version? - What's one deliverable you could give in 1 day? - How would you get feedback?

Exercise 3: The Agile Sprint

Design a mini-sprint: - Break a project into 5 stories - Estimate time for each - Define what "done" looks like

Exercise 4: The Interview Question

In your next interview, ask: - "How does the company define product success?" - "What's the product roadmap?" - "How does the team gather customer feedback?"

Book Recommendations

1. **The Mom Test** by Rob Fitzpatrick — How to talk to customers and get honest feedback. Essential for product thinking.
2. **22 Laws of Marketing** by Al Ries & Jack Trout — Classic marketing principles. Understand how positioning works.
3. **The Lean Startup** by Eric Ries — Build-measure-learn. The foundation of modern product development.
4. **Inspired** by Marty Cagan — How to create products customers love. The product manager's bible.
5. **Escaping the Build Trap** by Melissa Perri — How to ensure you're building the right things.
6. **The Design of Everyday Things** by Don Norman — UX fundamentals. How to make products usable and intuitive.

Reflection Questions

1. What does "product" mean to you now? Has your definition expanded?

2. What's one way you could apply the "product lens" to your current work?
3. How do you currently handle feedback? How could you get it earlier?
4. What's one project you could break into an MVP approach?

Next Workbook: Personal Growth — Preparing for Your Career Journey.

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